



Santander AD DC Server Upgrade & Domain Services Functional Level Promotion

Between March 2017 and December 2017, I led a critical infrastructure upgrade for Santander's Active Directory Domain Controller (AD DC) environment, modernising the platform to support future scalability, security, and compliance requirements across the organisation's financial-services operations.

Project Overview

The initiative focused on upgrading in-situ domain controller servers to Windows Server 2008 R2, followed by a promotion of the AD DS forest and domain functional levels. This ensured alignment with Microsoft's latest enterprise standards and enabled advanced identity-management capabilities.

Key Deliverables

- **Server OS Upgrade:** Transitioned legacy DC servers to Windows Server 2008 R2, improving performance and patch compliance.
- **Functional Level Promotion:** Elevated AD DS forest and domain functional levels to unlock enhanced authentication, replication, and policy features.
- **Risk Mitigation:** Implemented rollback and validation plans to ensure zero downtime during upgrade windows.
- **Testing & Validation:** Conducted pre-production testing, schema verification, and replication health checks across multiple sites.
- **Stakeholder Coordination:** Worked with infrastructure, security, and compliance teams to align technical changes with Santander's governance framework.

Outcome

The upgrade delivered a secure, stable, and future-ready Active Directory environment, improving operational resilience and enabling subsequent integration with newer Microsoft technologies. It also strengthened Santander's ability to manage identity and access across its global financial network.

Impact

- Enhanced security posture and compliance alignment
- Improved directory performance and replication efficiency
- Established a foundation for future cloud and hybrid identity initiatives